



that sells 3.7 billion movie tickets a year (compared to 1.4 billion in the US). What translates internationally is faith in your subject and narrative style. When Aamir Khan and Ashutosh Gowariker made a 3-hour-44-minute movie about cricket in Awadhi, they didn't do so with an eye on the Oscars. They did it because they believed in it. Our movies have intervals, they have songs which move the narrative forward (or should) and they have a distinct syntax. We should not let that go in our quest to be a global force. Even as Warner Bros, Sony and Fox Studios set up base here, we must not forget our primary audience is still domestic.



Yes, what we should do is write better stories. There was a time when everyone was a critic. Now everyone is a writer who believes he can make a better movie than half of Bollywood. This is the most amazing thing about technology. As creators of content, it puts us directly in touch with the people we are making it for. I joined Twitter three weeks ago and already I have 7,000 followers. It's an amazing platform for me to share my vision, get instant feedback and immediate correction. Digital technology is reshaping the production, marketing and distribution of content, in dealing with viewers who increasingly want to share in the creative process. From the YouTube culture it will soon become the wetube culture.

For filmmakers like us, it is imperative that we step out of our glass chambers and listen in to these changes, to connect with viewers. It opens us the vistas of our head, which is why I

believe a filmmaker is no different from a politician. If they don't deliver, they are voted out. If we don't deliver, we are simply not watched. Ironically, in the midst of such ferment in cinema, where a *Dev.D* acquires a fanatical following and *A Wednesday* generates more awareness than a multi-crore blockbuster, television remains firmly rooted in family politics. If any of our movies tried to espouse the regressive values that our soaps champion, we would be lynched. And yet, I suppose there is something oddly comforting in watching a validation of our deepest held values, ones that we would not like to publicly own up to.

I see it in myself. There I was sitting up all night watching the finale of *Rakhi ka Swayamwar*, alternately charmed and horrified by what was going on, feeling foolish and yet buying into the elaborate marriage routine. I look at my mother, convent-educated, well-travelled, politically savvy, addicted to soaps that go back in time. She tells me that she enjoys being involved in the politics of other families. And I see myself, while having dinner, also watching these shows with my mouth open.

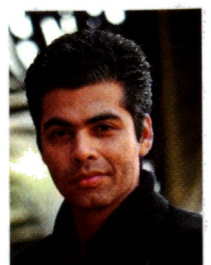
But I believe in the power of the cinema

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audience that is searching for something contemporary. At least once a month, I am blown away by a new idea at the movies. It may be half-formed, not fully developed, yet it exists. We are going back to the golden age of the '40s and '50s when there was a flowering of talent in Indian cinema. As we enter a new decade, I think change will come faster and more dramatically. The world is far more accepting and aware of our cinema than ever before. There will be more collaborations on a global scale, Indian stories will find echoes elsewhere and our exotic nature, something the US tends to seek in the rest of the world, will be appreciated for its authenticity. And as long as we filmmakers choose to make films we want to watch, rather than make what we think the world and India, wants to watch, the future is safe. There is no doubt we will become bigger and better. Just like those who watch us every week.

By 2013, the total number of TV-owning households in India is estimated to be about 149 million, up from 123 million in 2008.

9.1% is the estimated growth rate of the film industry over the next five years. It will reach a size of Rs 169 billion by 2013.



Karan Johar is a filmmaker